

Setting Up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

Low-Code Application Development

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Platform Architecture Overview

- Zoho Creator has a layered, low-code architecture — from user access down to deployment.
- **Access Layer:** Web Browser, Mobile App (iOS/Android), Customer/Partner Portal, Microservices/API Clients, Embedded Widgets.
- **Presentation Layer:** Pages (dashboards, layouts), Reports (list, Kanban, calendar, pivot), Forms (drag-and-drop data entry).
- **Application & Logic Layer:** Workflow Engine (automation), Deluge Scripting (custom logic), Microservices, Integrations (APIs, payment gateways, marketplace apps).
- **Data Layer:** Cloud Database (multi-tenant), File & Attachment Storage, Audit Trail & Backup.
- **Governance & Security:** Users & Role-Based Access, Security Policies/MFA, Organization Settings, Domains/Active Directory.
- **Deployment & Lifecycle:** Stage Environment, Production Environment, Version History/Publish, Mobile Rebranding/Distribution.
- **Monitoring & Administration** spans the entire stack — Metrics & Analytics, Operations Console (logs, audit, backup), Billing & Subscription Management.

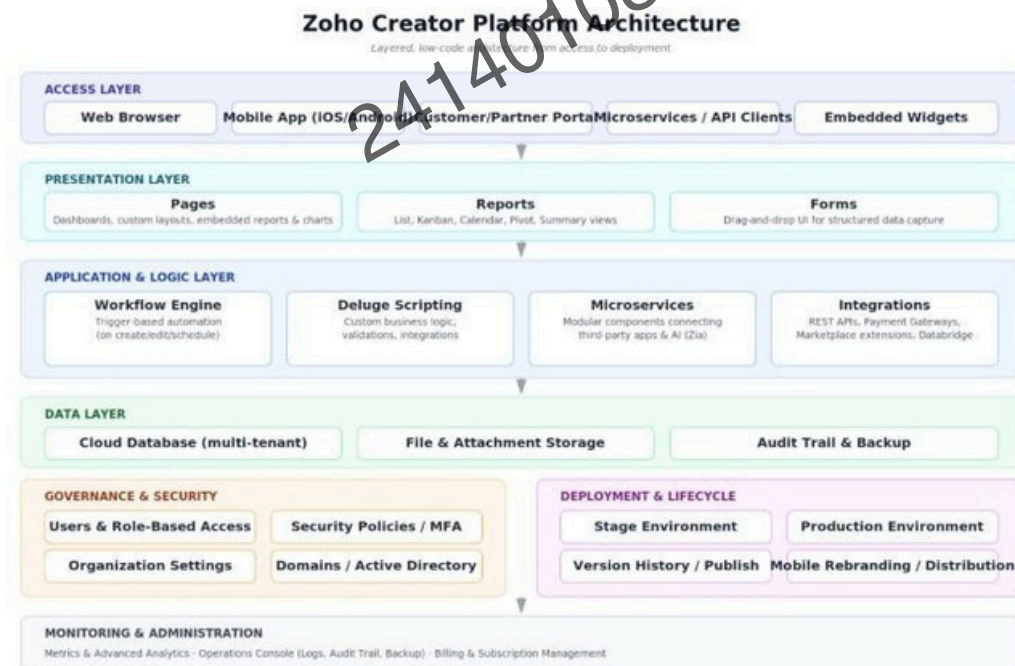


Figure: Zoho Creator Platform Architecture — layered, low-code architecture from access to deployment

Introduction

- Zoho Creator is a low-code platform for building business applications using drag-and-drop tools and AI assistance instead of hand-written code.
- This report documents a hands-on exploration of the Zoho Creator account setup and its three core functional areas: **Develop**, **Deploy**, and **Manage**.

- Each section pairs a platform screenshot with a short, simple explanation of what the feature does and where it fits in the application lifecycle.

1. Application Dashboard

- Opens automatically after sign-in, under the **Develop** menu.
- Every card here represents a **Solution** — a complete business application created in the account.
- Shows sample apps already created in the account.
- The "**Create Application**" button (top right) is the starting point for building any new app.

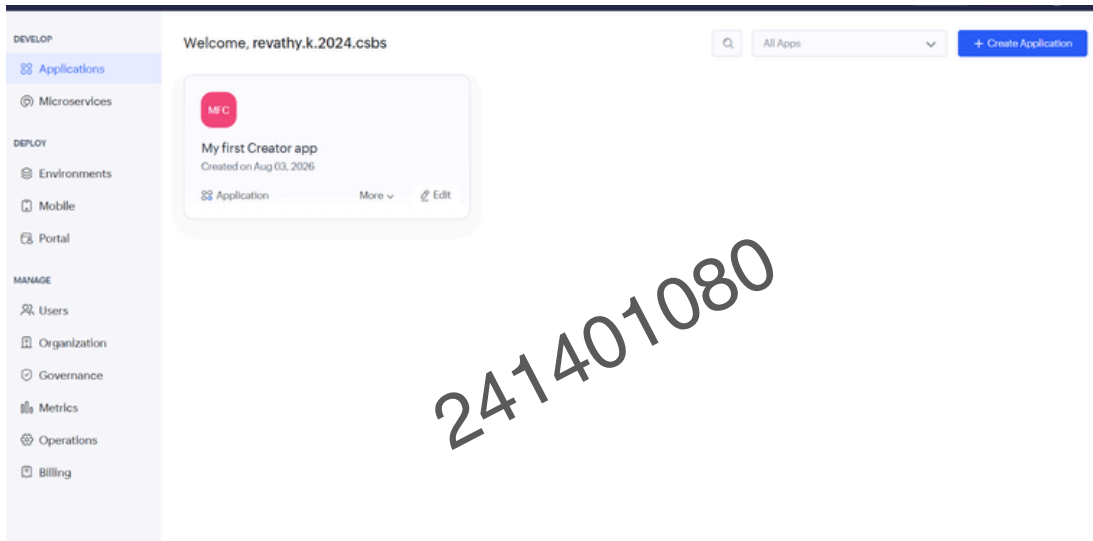


Figure 1: Application Dashboard screen in Zoho Creator

2. Microservices

- Also found under **Develop**; shown empty if none have been created yet.
- A Microservice is a small, independent, reusable unit of backend logic (e.g., a shared tax-calculation function or authentication check).
- Can be called from multiple Solutions instead of rebuilding the same logic in each app.
- Similar to a function library in traditional programming — write once, reuse anywhere.

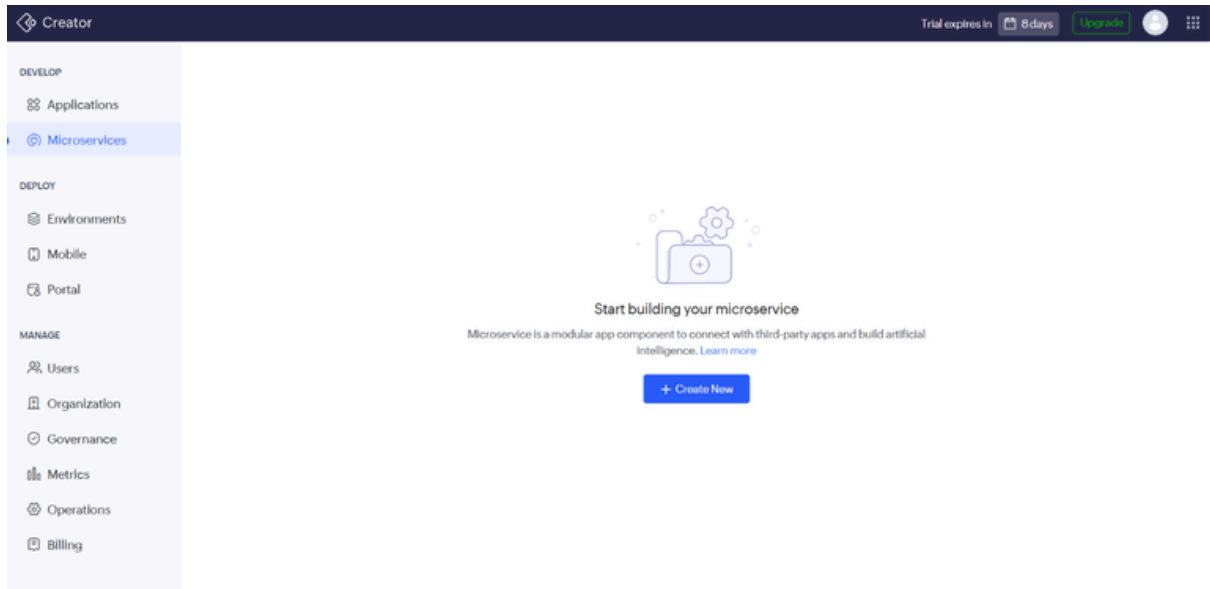


Figure 2: Microservices screen in Zoho Creator

3. Environments

- Found under **Deploy**; organizes an application's lifecycle into separate stages.
- Two main environments: **Stage** (for testing) and **Production** (live, used by real users).
- Development = where features are actively built; Stage = where the app is verified; Production = the live version.
- Keeping these separate prevents unfinished changes from affecting real users.

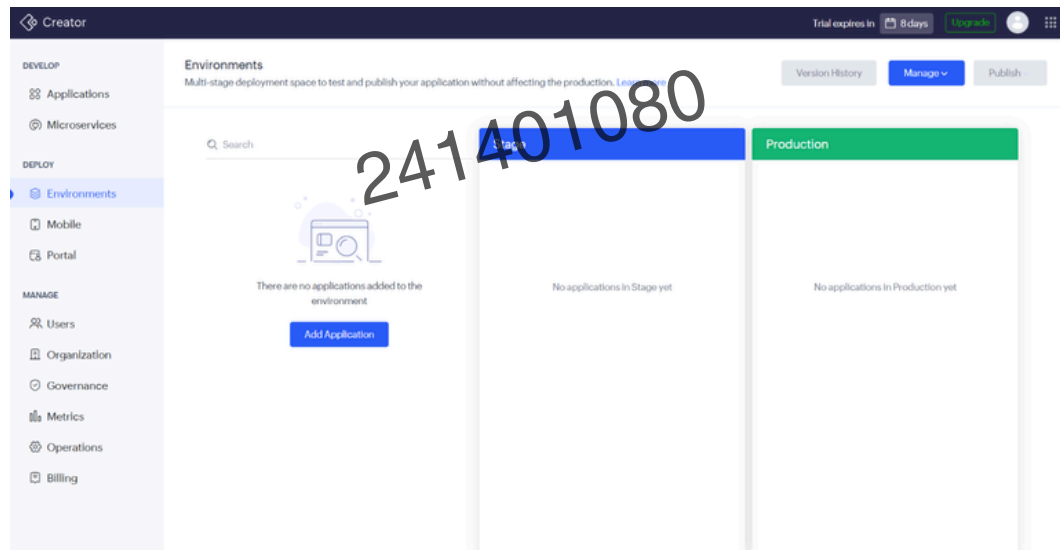


Figure 3: Environments screen in Zoho Creator

4. Mobile

- Also part of **Deploy**; automatically adapts an app's layout for phones and tablets — no separate mobile development needed.

- Option to download the app as a branded mobile application or distribute it via Play Store/App Store (requires account upgrade).
- Mobile access is treated as a natural extension of the same app, not a rebuild.

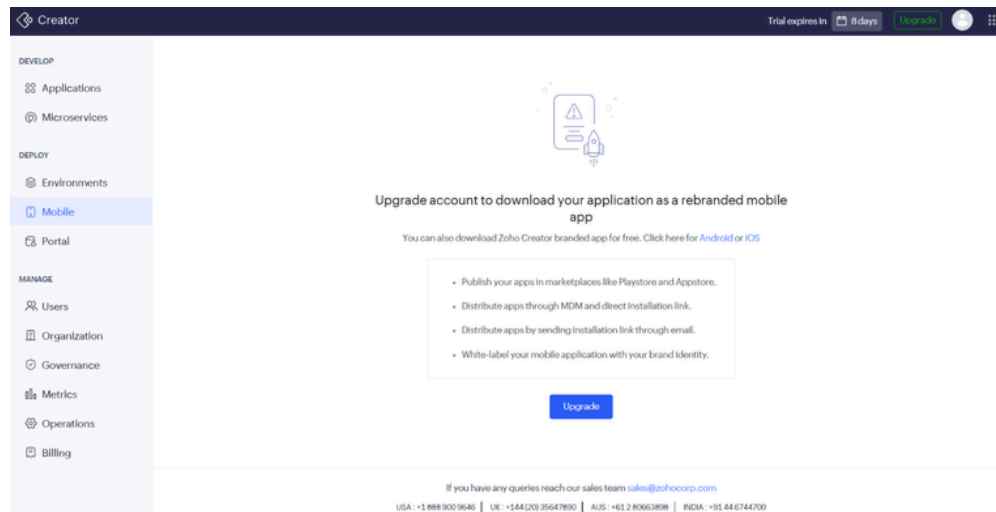


Figure 4: Mobile screen in Zoho Creator

5. Portal

- The third piece of the **Deploy** stage.
- A Portal gives external users (customers, vendors, the public) a controlled, branded window into the application.
- Does not expose internal data or the full admin interface.
- "Create Now" is the starting point for setting up external-facing access.

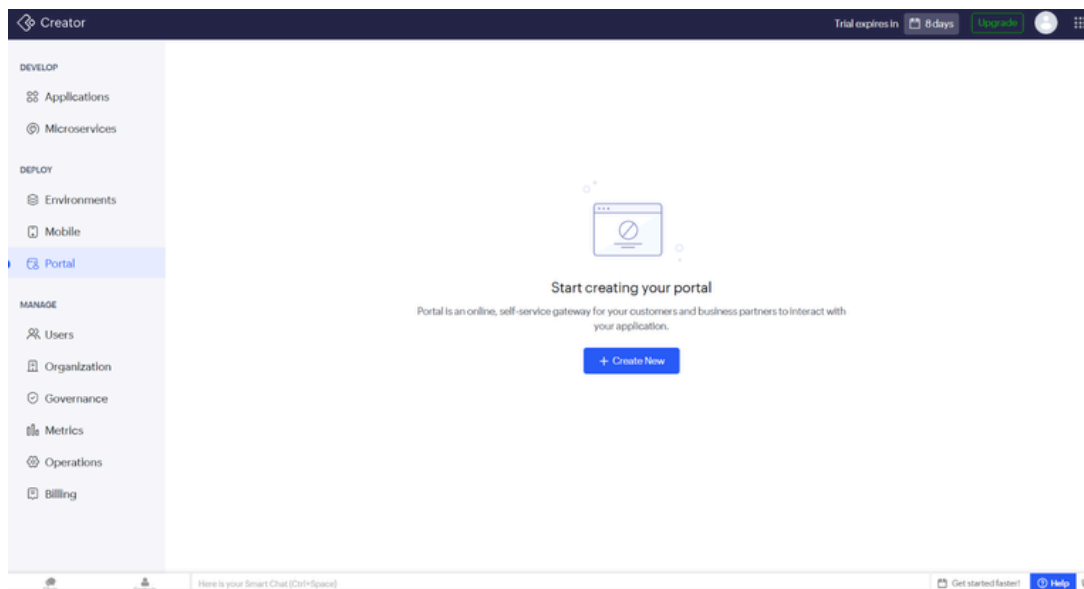


Figure 5: Portal screen in Zoho Creator

6. Users

- First screen under the **Manage** section.
- Lists everyone with access to the account (e.g., the account owner as an active user).
- Administrators can add, remove, and assign roles/permissions to control access.

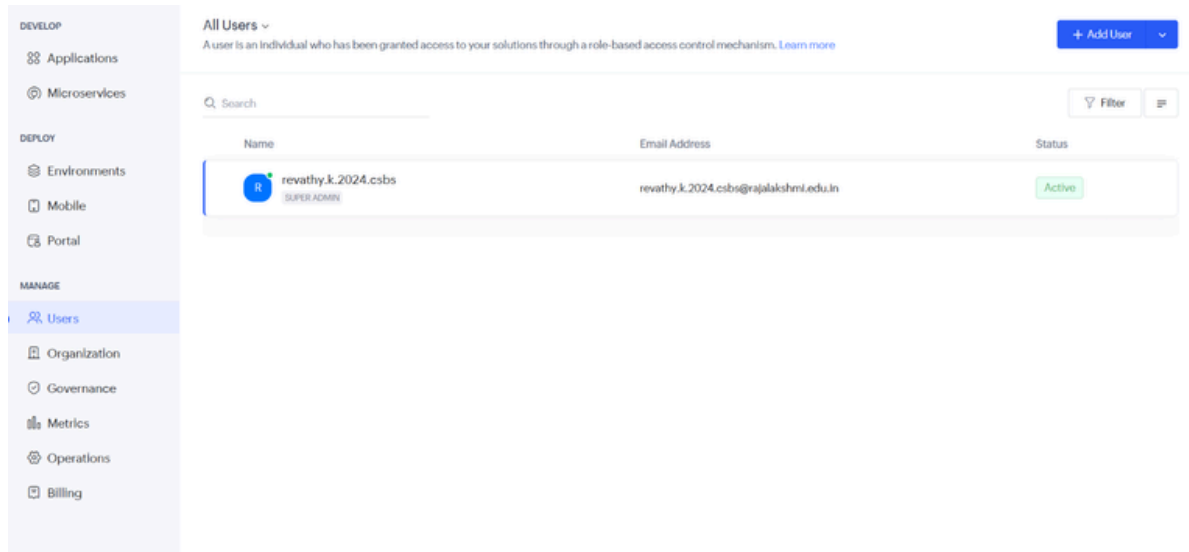


Figure 6: Users screen in Zoho Creator

7. Organization

- Holds company-wide account details: logo, favicon, contact information.
- Includes super-admin details such as email and phone.
- Preferences include organization subdomain and time zone.
- This defines the account-level identity, separate from any individual application.

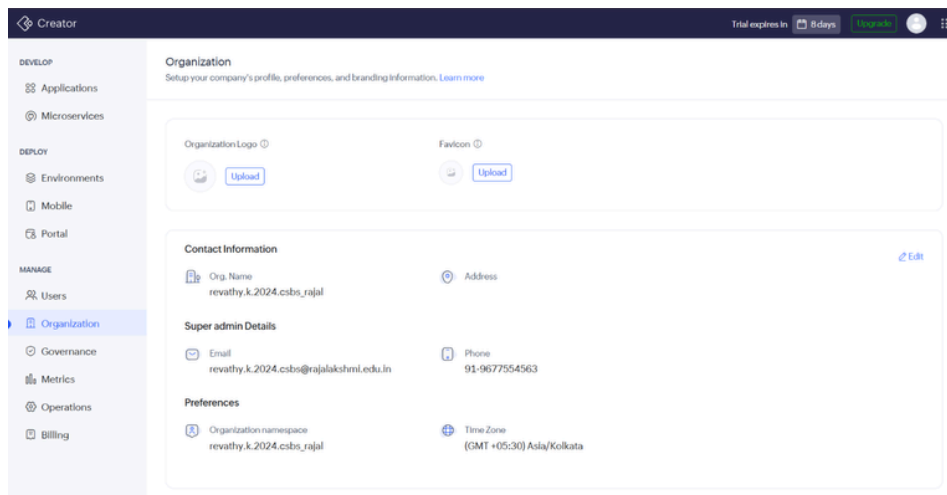


Figure 7: Organization screen in Zoho Creator

8. Governance

- Sets compliance rules, data policies, and audit controls for the account.
- The Security Policies tab lets admins configure settings (like password rules, MFA) that apply across every application.
- Helps keep data handling and access consistent as the account grows.

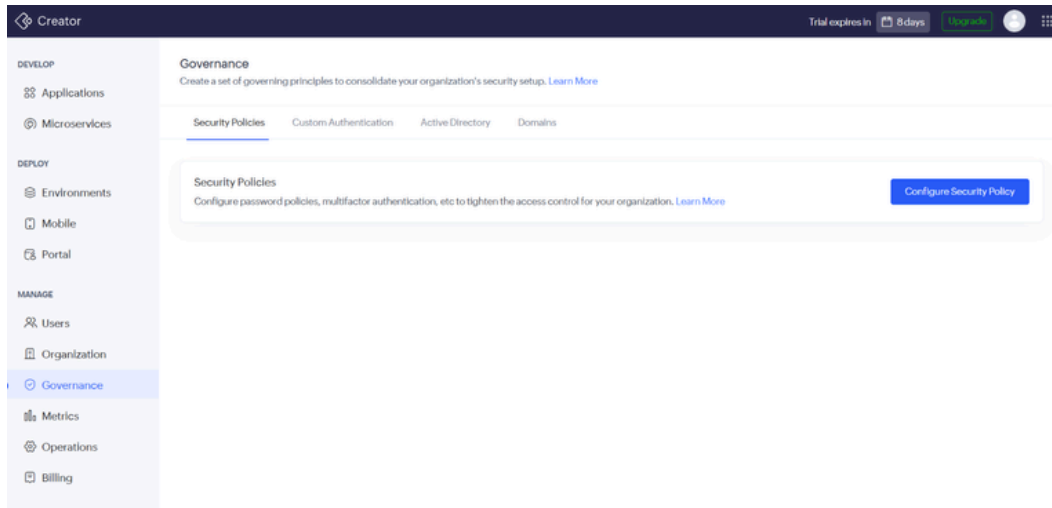


Figure 8: Governance screen in Zoho Creator

9. Metrics

- Tracks usage statistics: applications accessed, live applications, daily average hits per application.
- Includes charts for application access trend and usage summary.
- Gives administrators visibility into adoption and performance over time.

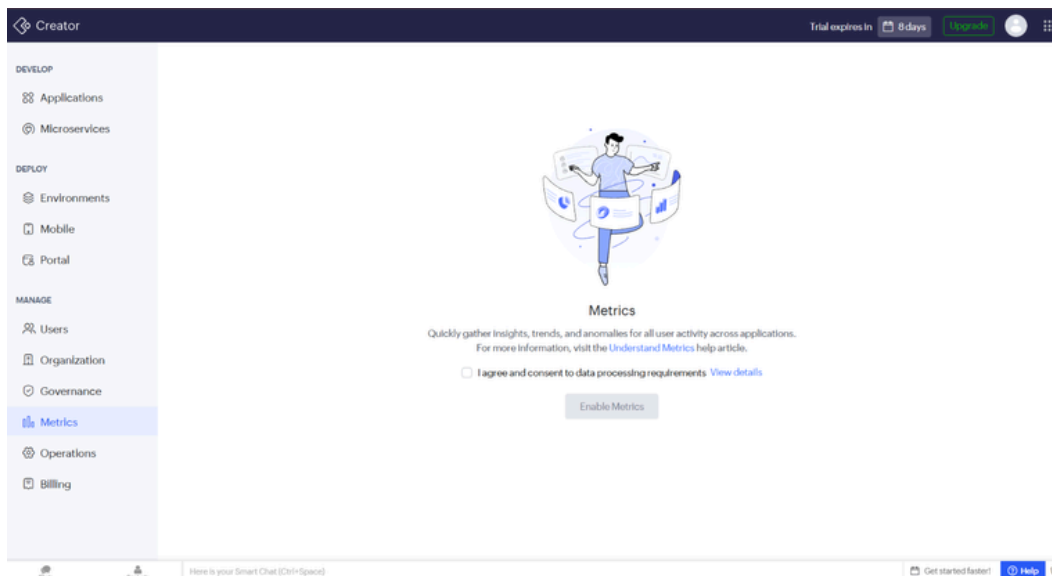


Figure 9: Metrics screen in Zoho Creator

10. Operations

- Provides advanced, behind-the-scenes management tools grouped under Applications.
- Includes backup, audit trail, domain restriction, API management, logs, publish, form email, and more.
- Also covers support access, system integrations, Zia (AI), payment gateways, and marketplace tools.
- This is the control center for keeping applications running reliably.

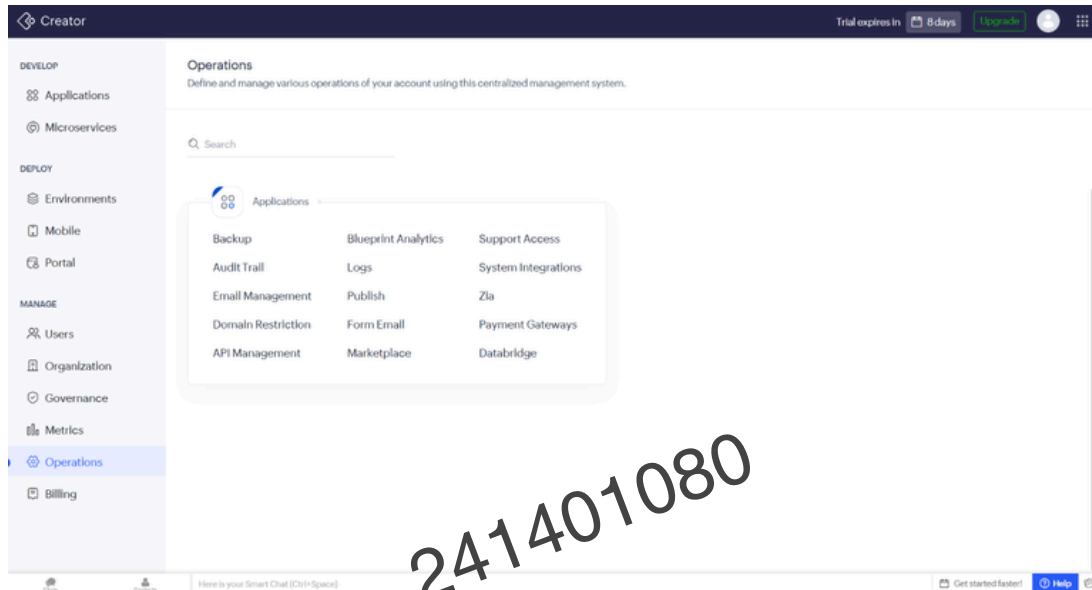


Figure 10: Operations screen in Zoho Creator

11. Billing

- Gives a comprehensive overview of the account's active subscription.
- Shows plan details such as user limits and app limits, plus an option to upgrade.
- Usage Details section monitors component-level usage, metrics, and custom alerts.
- A useful last step to confirm what the account is entitled to and when action is needed.

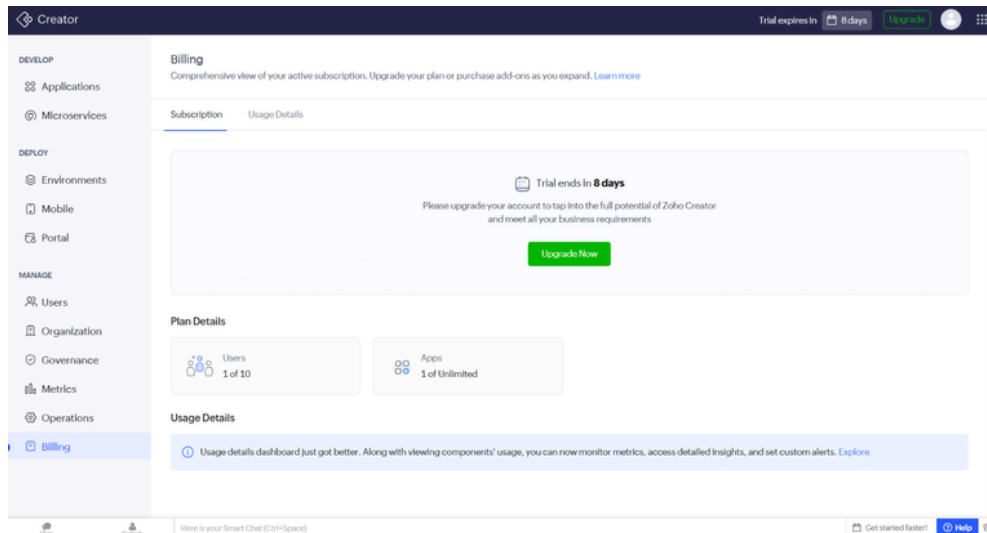


Figure 11: Billing screen in Zoho Creator

Conclusion

- This exploration walked through Zoho Creator's account setup and its three core functional areas.
- **Develop** (Applications, Microservices) — where an app's forms, logic, and reusable components are built.
- **Deploy** (Environments, Mobile, Portal) — governs how the finished app is released and shared.
- **Manage** (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing) — covers the ongoing administrative responsibilities.
- Together, these three areas represent the complete lifecycle of a low-code application, from first build to everyday operation.